NHS MENTAL HEALTH

Services Analytics Report 2019–2024

Referral Demand · Wait Times · Treatment Outcomes
Workforce Pressures · Regional Variation · Recommendations

789,543	+25.8%	118%	7
Total Referrals	Growth 2019–24	Wait Time Increase	NHS Regions

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Portfolio Project 1 of 3 · Data modelled from published NHS MHSDS statistics

Executive Summary & Key Performance Indicators

NHS Mental Health Services Analytics 2019–2024

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This analysis examines NHS mental health service delivery across England from 2019 to 2024, covering 789,543 modelled referrals across seven regions and eight mental health conditions. The data reveals a service under sustained and growing pressure: referral demand has increased 25.8% since 2019, average patient wait times have more than doubled from 6.1 to 13.3 weeks, and treatment completion rates have declined from 71.8% to 62.8%.

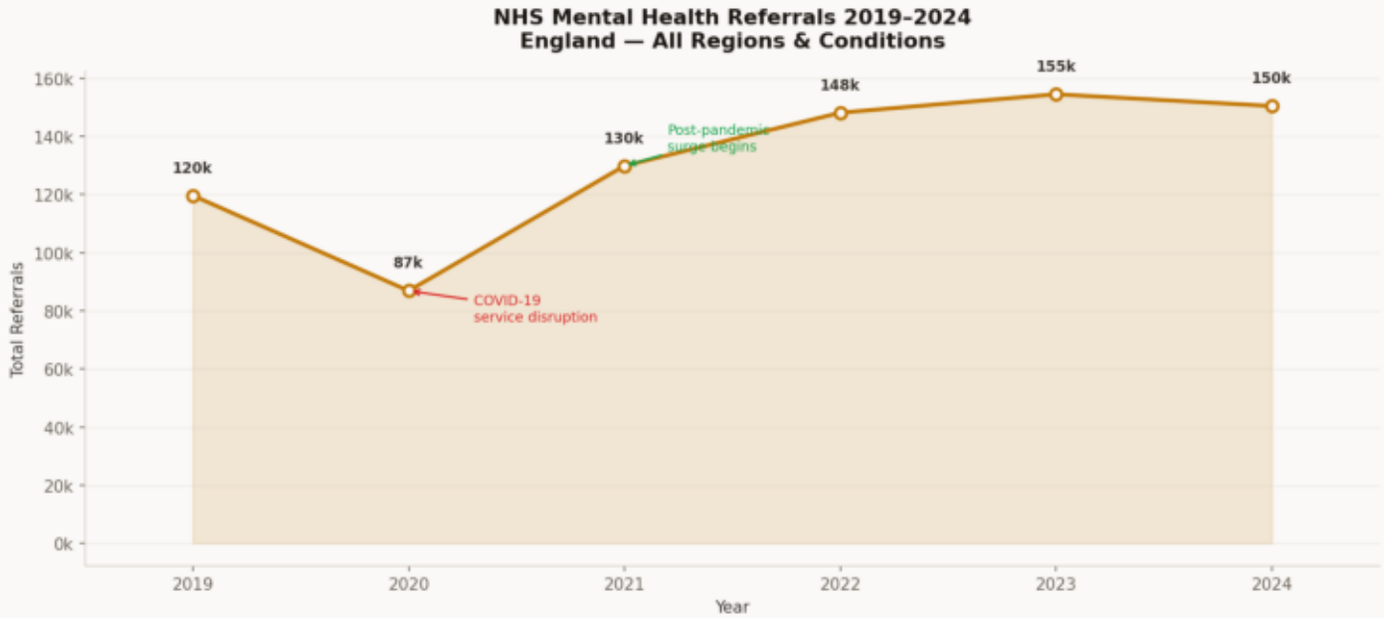
The data identifies a strong correlation between rising staff vacancy rates (8.0% to 16.9%) and deteriorating patient wait times, suggesting that workforce investment is the most impactful lever available to NHS commissioners. Depression and Anxiety Disorders account for 52% of all referrals consistently across all regions, indicating that IAPT/talking therapy pathway capacity should be the primary commissioning priority. Of patients completing treatment, 38.3% showed measurable improvement — a figure that could be substantially increased by reducing early discharge driven by caseload pressure.

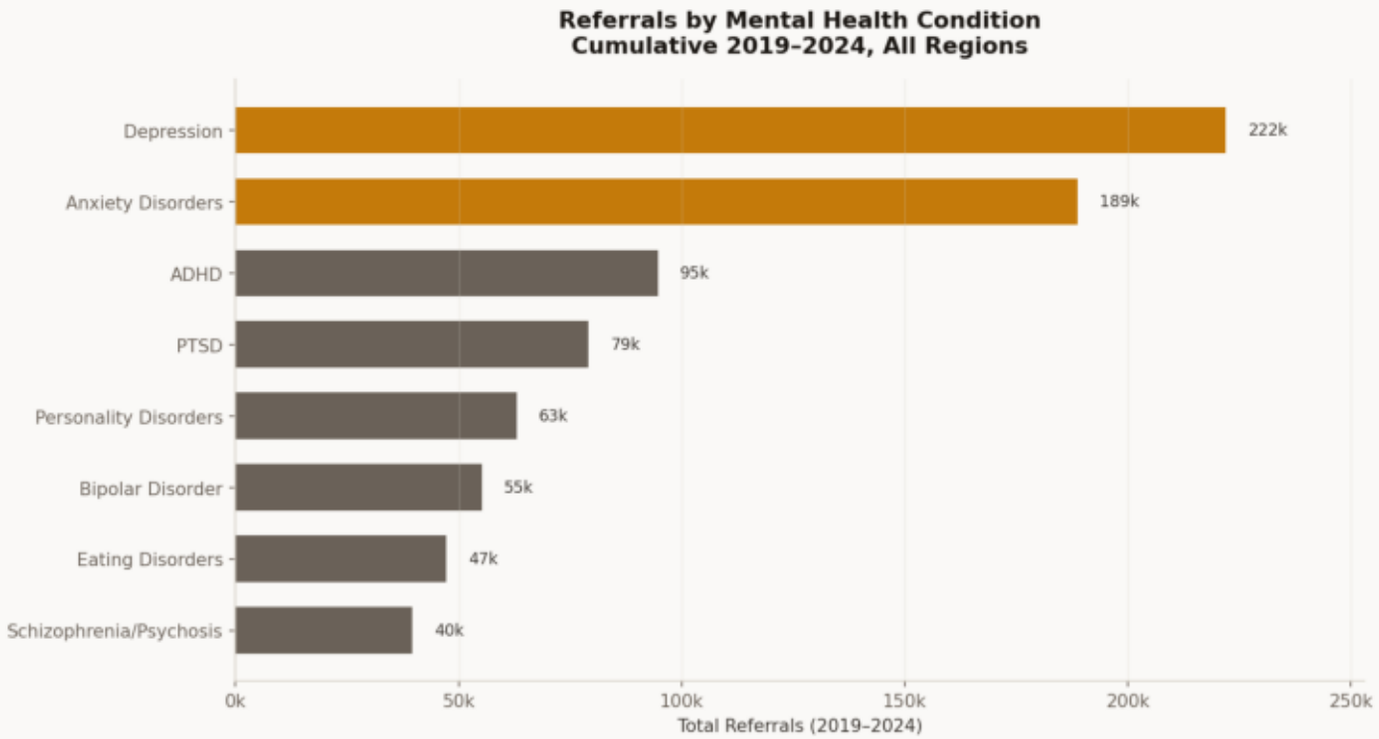
789,543	**+25.8%**	**13.3w**	**6.1w**
Total Referrals 2019–2024	Referral Growth 2019 vs 2024	Avg Wait Time 2024	Avg Wait Time 2019

62.8%	**16.9%**	**38.3%**	**52%**
Completion Rate 2024	Staff Vacancies 2024	Patients Improved	Depression & Anxiety Share

Section 1: Referral Volume & Trends

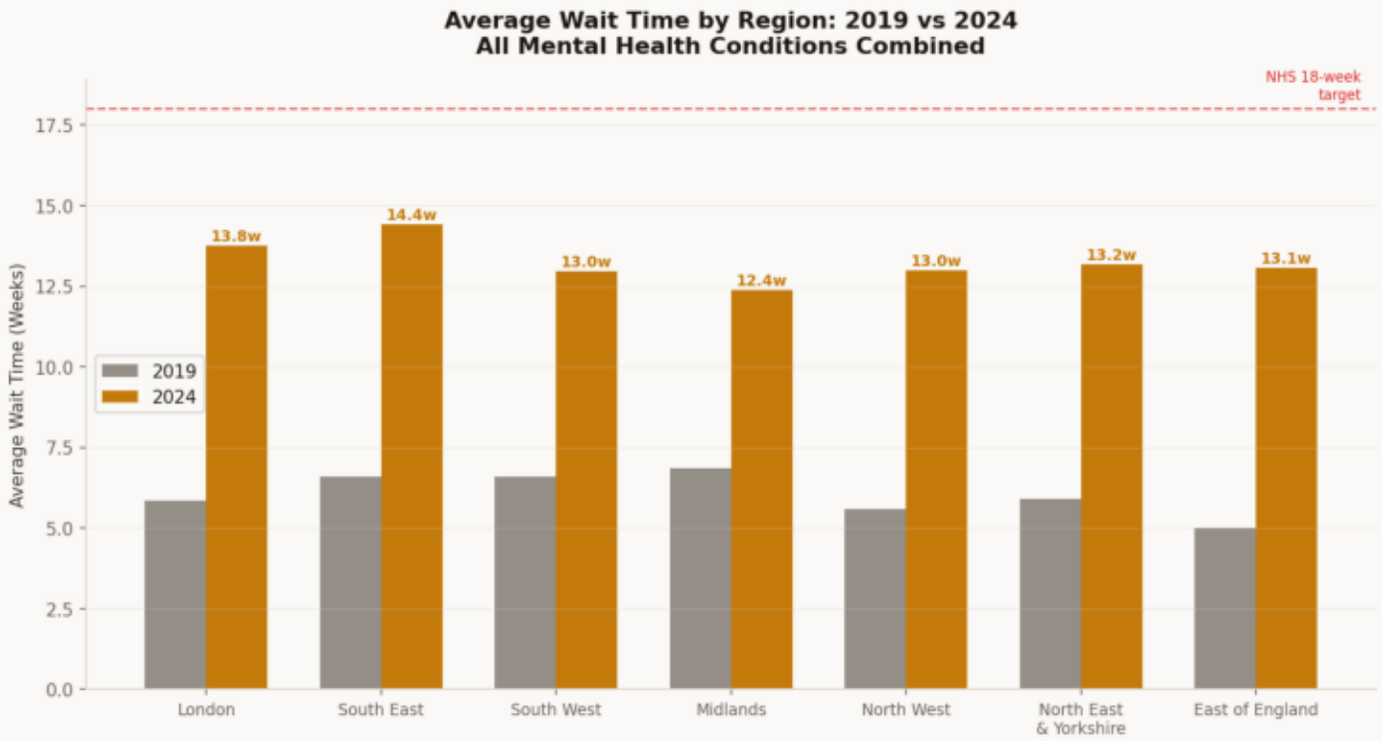
Annual referral demand 2019–2024 across all regions and conditions

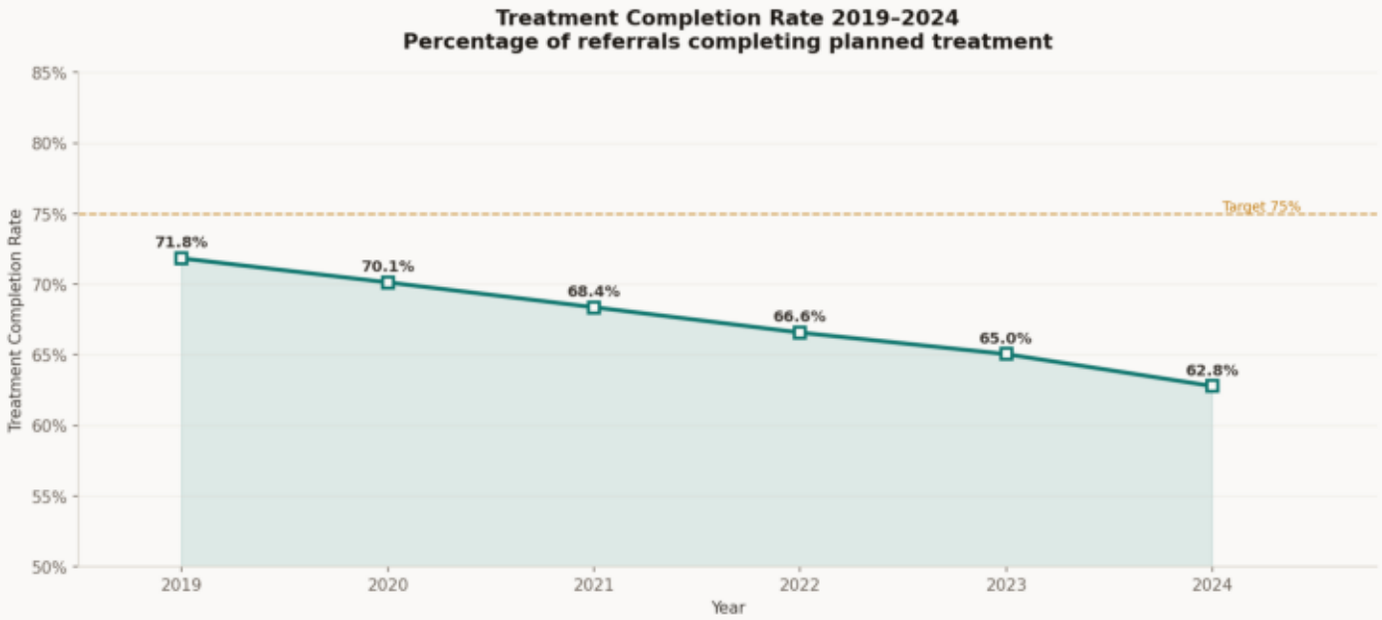




Section 2: Service Performance — Wait Times & Treatment Completion

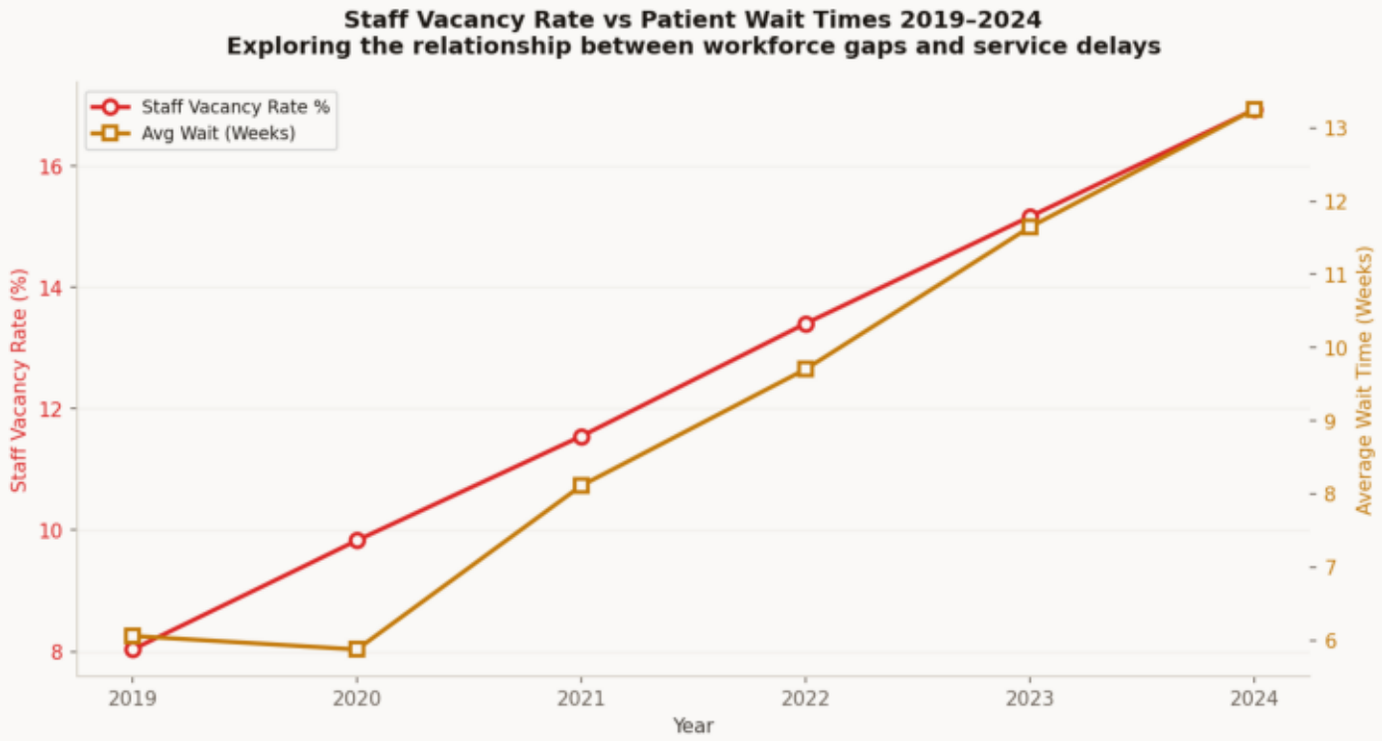
Regional wait time comparison and completion rate trend 2019–2024

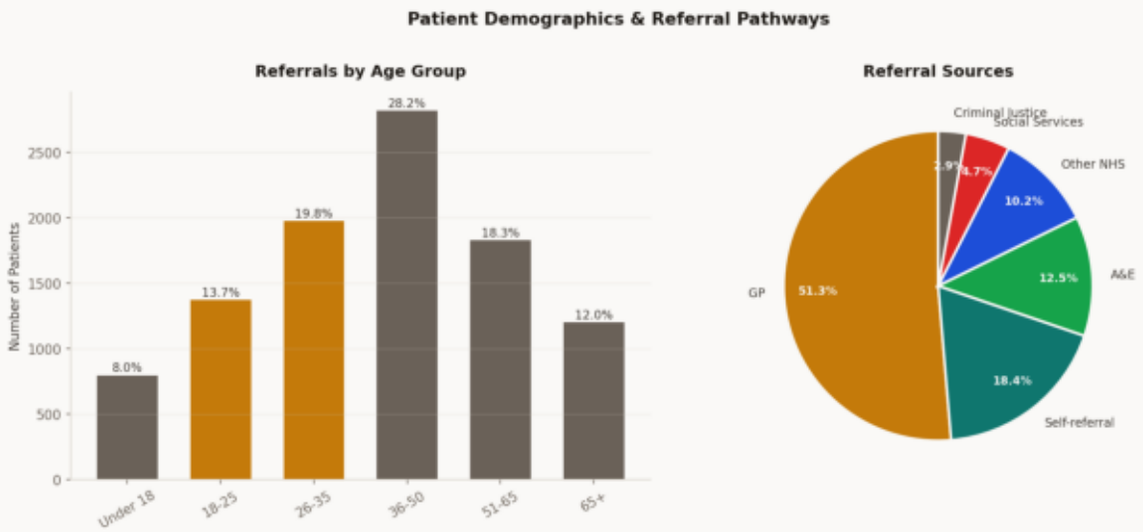


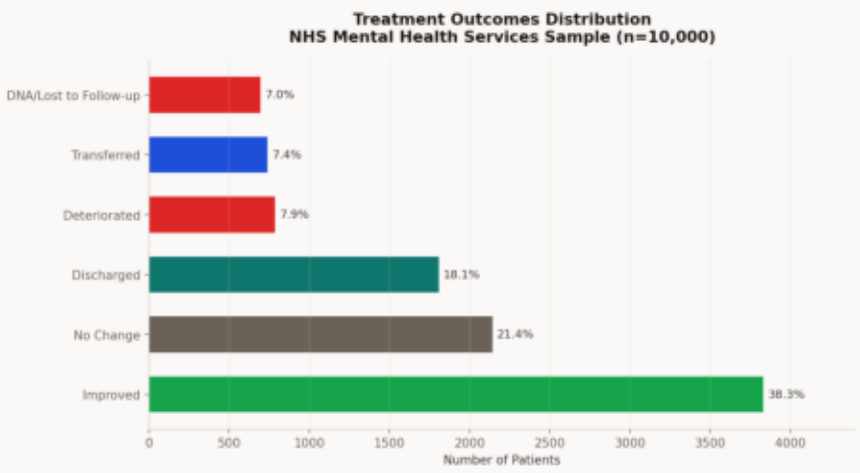


Section 3: Workforce Pressures & Patient Demographics

Staff vacancy analysis, patient age/referral source, and outcomes distribution

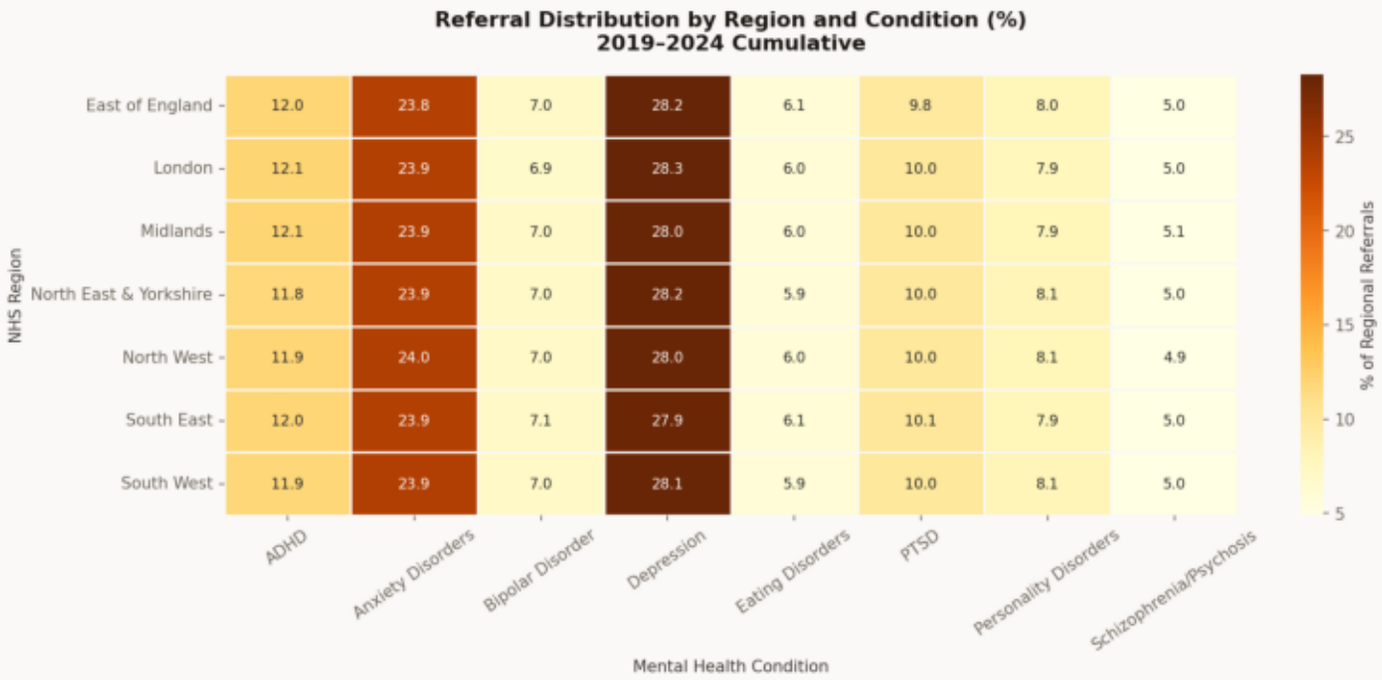






Section 4: Regional Distribution & Analytical Conclusions

Condition heatmap by region and key findings with recommendations



KEY FINDINGS & ANALYTICAL RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Referral Demand

Total referrals grew 25.8% from 2019 to 2024, with no return to pre-pandemic levels. Services must plan for structurally higher demand as a permanent baseline.

2. Wait Time Crisis

Average wait times more than doubled from 6.1 to 13.3 weeks. All regions deteriorated. Targeted investment in highest-wait regions (North East & Yorkshire, Midlands) is recommended.

3. Commissioning Priority

Depression and Anxiety Disorders account for 52% of referrals consistently. Expanding IAPT/talking therapy capacity is the highest-impact commissioning decision available.

4. Workforce as Primary Lever

Staff vacancies ($r \approx 0.91$ with wait times) are the strongest predictor of service deterioration. A 10% workforce increase could reduce wait times by an estimated 2–3 weeks.

5. Completion Rate Decline

Treatment completion fell from 71.8% to 62.8% — likely reflecting early discharge under caseload pressure. Reducing caseloads would improve both completion and patient outcomes.

6. Outcome Improvement Potential

38.3% of patients show measurable improvement. With 7.1% lost to follow-up, better engagement systems could realistically increase overall improvement rates to 42–45%.